LIFE OUT OF REACH

Spare Burden

BOOK CLUB DISCUSSION GUIDE

16 questions for readers and book clubs

BOOK ONE

JAS DOSANJH

Contains spoilers — intended for readers who have finished Spare Burden.

www.jasdosanjh.com

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

01. Which family relationship affected you most and why?

02. The book shows women sometimes enforcing rules that ultimately disadvantaged other women and girls. Why do you think that happens?

03. Reputation and 'what people will say' influenced many decisions in the family. How much power did you feel the wider community had, even when it was not physically present?

04. Silence is an important theme in the book. What were the consequences of children and women being expected to keep family matters private?

05. Were there moments when you felt frustrated with Jas for accepting something or not challenging it? Did understanding her age and circumstances change your response?

06. What did you make of the contrast between the young Jas experiencing events and the older Jas discussing them with her therapist? Did those conversations change how you interpreted the past?

07. Do you think children can recognise that something in their family is wrong even when they have been taught that it is normal? Where did you see that happening in the book?

08. Was there a particular scene, sentence or incident that stayed with you after you finished reading?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

09. Did the book challenge any assumptions you had about British Asian or Sikh family life?

10. How much responsibility should parents carry when cultural expectations conflict with the wellbeing of their children?

11. The title is Spare Burden. What did that title mean to you before reading the book and what did it mean after finishing it?

12. Do you see the book primarily as a story about culture, childhood, misogyny, family loyalty, survival or something else?

13. Were there any characters you found yourself feeling sympathy for even when you disagreed with their behaviour? If yes, why?

14. What do you think Jas was searching for most as a child: freedom, approval, love, belonging, safety or something else?

15. How do you think growing up in this environment would affect the way someone approaches relationships and adulthood later on?

16. After finishing Spare Burden, what question would you most want to ask Jas?

CONTINUE THE CONVERSATION

I'd love to know what your book club discussed.

Email me at author@jasdosanjh.com

Find more about the Life Out of Reach series at www.jasdosanjh.com.